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In the United States, fast-paced and ever changing COVID messaging has created two sets of facts, which can be used to corroborate opposing viewpoints. By adding some perspective, however, it is possible to retreat from opposing corners and meet in the middle. Americans can find their way back to each other by seeing the good intentions through foggy messaging; doing so may even help clear the air and reduce stress.

An early divergence of public opinion around COVID emerged with mask mandates. Initial public health direction from the Center for Disease Control and Prevent (CDC) stated that facemasks were not recommended (Fig. 1). However, three months into the pandemic, in March of 2020, the US was facing a shortage. In a bid to keep masks available for healthcare workers, US Surgeon General, Jerome Adams, tweeted "STOP BUYING MASKS! … They are NOT effective in preventing the general public from catching #Coronavirus…" (Fig. 2). As Americans began to process this information, on April 3rd, the CDC revised its guidance by recommending masking for the general public (Fig. 3). In the



Figure 1.

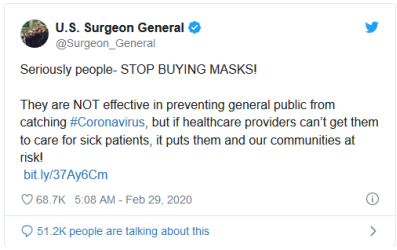


Figure 2.

span two months government officials created two opposing narratives, causing a split in opinion on mask efficacy. But a deeper look reveals the goal was to keep healthcare workers safe, so that they could continue to help save lives of those who were battling the virus.

Vaccine safety suffered from political entanglement, causing further divide between Americans. On May 15, 2020, President, Donald Trump, announced Operation Warp Speed, a program focused on approval and distribution of emergency-use vaccines by January 2021b (Fig. 4). In September, as vaccines made their way through trials, Trump was accused of pressuring the FDA to approve vaccines ahead of the election (Fig. 5). By October, the governors of New York, California, Washington, Oregon, and Nevada pledged to delay vaccines until independent panels determined they were safe (Fig. 6). The FDA approved the first COVID vaccine for emergency use on December 11, 2020. Within three days, governors of all four states approved the vaccines for use (Fig. 7.). Attempting to fast-track vaccine approval led to political fallout, making vaccines seem less safe. The speed with which politicians abandoned concerns of vaccine safety to embrace vaccine distribution made it seem like not enough time had been spent independently reviewing vaccines.



Fiure 3.



Figure 4.



Figure 5.



Figure 6.



Figure 7.

However, a careful assessment of the intentions of both political parties suggests noble intentions: vaccines were desperately needed, which meant bureaucratic delays needed to be reduced to save lives.

Requiring vaccinated Americans to wear masks is another topic of divide. In April of 2021, a CDC press release stated, “vaccinated adults 65 years and older were 94% less likely to be hospitalized with COVID-19” (Fig. 8). Two months later, the CDC released guidance confirming Americans who were fully vaccinated did not need to wear masks indoors. However, by the end of July, the CDC reversed their position, requiring vaccinated Americans to wear masks indoors once again. In August, research published in the *New England Journal of Medicine* showed Pfizer’s vaccine to be 93.7 effective against the alpha variant, and 88% effective against the delta variant of COVID 19 (Bernal et al.). By requiring vaccinated populations to wear face masks, the CDC introduced an unspoken message: vaccines do not accomplish their task of keeping people safe from COVID infection. Alternatively, masking helps reduce the spread of COVID from vaccinated to unvaccinated people. If vaccinated Americans are willing to make a small sacrifice, they can work toward keeping the unvaccinated safe.

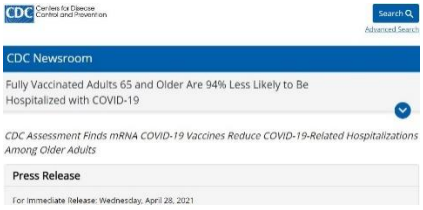


Figure 8.



Figure 9.



Figure 10.

Taking time to consider what public policy intends to accomplish, rather than getting stuck on how it is introduced is difficult but doing so reveals noble intent. Early in the pandemic, public officials sought to influence market trends so that healthcare workers could remain healthy and continue saving lives. Politicians who, at first glance, appear to be playing games for election purposes ultimately had the same goal of ensuring the Americans had access to safe and effective vaccines. Although it might seem contrary to the science, asking vaccinated people to wear masks could save the lives of the unvaccinated. By looking at these divisive topics at alternate angles, it becomes clear that there is more commonality than division. Examining the facts one relies can be difficult, but one thing everyone can agree on is that the pandemic has caused distress for everyone. Distress is the great equalizer, and coping with it demands no less than opposites unite to do reduce this shared burden. Take a step back, look at information from other angles, clear the air and become less stressed.

Works Cited

Bernal, Jamie, et al. “Effectiveness of Covid-19 Vaccines against the B.1.617.2 (Delta) Variant: Nejm.” *New England Journal of Medicine*, Massachusetts Medical Society, 12 Aug. 2021, DOI: 10.1056/NEJMoa2108891. Accessed 2 Nov. 2021.